SPORTS

MAKING OF A CHAMPION

Squash player ***Joshna Chinappa***'s Padma Shri is the icing on the cake of a storied career

IN January, Joshna Chinappa was travelling to Coorg to meet her father, Anjan, when she received a call from an unknown number. By the end of the conversation, the squash exponent was quite over the moon.

"An official informed me that I was being awarded the Padma Shri. I was pleasantly surprised as I wasn't expecting it," Chinappa, 37, says.

This was acknowledgment of a decorated career that has flourished for over two decades. Chinappa first turned out for India at the age of 12 in 1998, competing at the Asian Junior Championships in Malaysia. It gave her a good feel of what it was like to be a team player. A couple of years later, she won the Senior Nationals at just 14 years—a tournament she's gone on to win a record 19 times, the last title coming back in 2022. "From the time I was 13, I've had some good matches against Indians. This was what pushed me to train harder and be a better player," she says.

The early spark made it evident that Chinappa was cut out for the international stage. In 2003, she picked up her first major titles by winning the British Junior Open (U-17) and the Asian Junior Individual Championships (U-19)—the first Indian to do so. Two years later, she won both the tournaments again in the under-19 category.

After joining the senior ranks, she continued annexing titles in an individual capacity, rising to a career-best ranking of World No. 10 in July 2016. But it was as a team player that she created history for India time and again. She has a rich haul of two Commonwealth Games and five Asian Games medals over the last decade. Of the lot, she cherishes her first triumph, a doubles gold at the 2014 Commonwealth Games, the most. "That was a special win alongside Dipika [Pallikal Karthik] because it was the first time we managed gold for the country," she recalls.

It was with the same partner that Chinappa created history in 2022 by picking up gold at the World Doubles Championships—another first for India after her three previous bronze finishes. Her last major success was a team bronze at the 2022 Asian Games in Hangzhou, where the side featured players as inexperienced as 14-year-old Anahat Singh.

"When I started, I was the youngest and was looked out for by seniors. Today, I am the eldest and get along really well with youngsters like Anahat. The next generation has a lot of knowledge about the game. With their potential, they can go quite far, provided they work with the right team and have the financial support to play on the professional tour," she says.

That said, the past few years have been extremely demanding. Knee injuries have forced her to take time off; consequently, she is currently ranked outside the top 100. With squash set to make its debut at the 2028 Olympics, she's hopeful of extending her dream run for another few years.

"I've had to work harder and smarter as I've gotten older. To play at the highest level, I've had to ensure that I keep putting in the work physically to compete against younger players. It means not over-training and giving my body time to recover, while also being good with nutrition. Only I know how hard it is to give up chocolates!" says Chinappa. ■

–Shail Desai

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